That there could be an empirical grey zone over such a stark and undeniable fact as mortality may seem improbable. But India is at the centre of a raging debate over precisely such a thing, with the World Health Organization (WHO) offering an estimate of Covid-19 deaths in India that's nearly 10 times the official toll. Scepticism on official data is not an unknown sentiment at the best of times, and Covid is a particularly sensitive topic—India is not immune to the universal tendency to under-report mortality. But the jousting here is ultimately between two sets of estimates, which leaves a core question unanswered: will we ever know how many died in the pandemic?

The key debate relates to methodology. India's official Covid death toll stood at 481,000 at the end of 2021. On May 5, WHO released numbers that pegged it around 4.74 million. The first is a count of actual deaths registered as occurring due to Covid. The route the WHO took to arrive at its estimate, on the other hand, is via the framework of 'excess deaths'. The phrase describes the difference between the average 'all-cause mortality'—the expected number of total deaths across a specific time period—and what was seen during the pandemic. That is, by working backwards from a general estimate to another estimate—by no means a foolproof procedure. But despite India's vehement protestations, perhaps it is not entirely off-track in its general assumptions. As WHO noted, Covid deaths started spiking towards the second half of 2020 and over half of India's excess deaths (2,721,643) happened during the deadly Delta wave, in April-June 2021. Strictly speaking, as evidence, the pictures of untended corpses on riverbanks may count as anecdotal,



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

but they did speak an essential truth. It was India's worst health crisis in living memory, and the system very nearly collapsed under a tsunami of deaths. Not unreasonable to expect, then, that the data itself suffered for want of oxygen.

The WHO number is, of course, *all* excess deaths—those directly from Covid, those due to secondary issues sparked by Covid, and of non-Covid patients who died due to lack of treatment. The second category is slightly tricky: governments were said to be routinely filing those as non-Covid deaths to keep their tolls low. Working via all-cause mortality eliminates the potential sleight of hand there. Although not offered as exact, the total figure does yield a measure of the scale of the pandemic.

The report, ready by December 2021, was kept on hold due to India's objections. "India feels the process was neither collaborative nor adequately representative," the government said in a statement to the UN Statistical Commission in February 2021. Additional analyses and model checks were done before the report finally saw the light of day. The Indian government remains firmly unconvinced. "The data is questionable and based on media reports and unconfirmed sources. (That) isn't scientifically correct, especially when you have robust official data," says AIIMS director Dr Randeep Guleria.

One set of data at stake here is from the Civil Registration System